

AASU Higher Education Quality Assurance Ambassadors Project (QAP)

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BACKGROUND

Socio-economic development has been moving steadily in many countries, resulting in a better standard of living for citizens in those countries. It is clear, however, that the colonial and other exploitative legacies have left deep imprints, which in most cases, in more than half a century of self-determination, have hindered African countries from achieving full development particularly with regards to education. This has been exacerbated by national and regional conflicts, poor governance, corruption, and injudicious use and management of available resources. In most cases, the scale of challenges related to socio-economic development has been overwhelming, and disproportionate to the resources available to address them adequately and sustainably (African Standards and Guidelines- Quality Assurance, 2018).

The African Union Commission (AUC) has, at the highest level, called for harmonization and strengthening of the African higher education quality so as to make it locally relevant and globally competitive. This is in line with the AUC's vision articulated in the document Agenda 2063 "The Africa We Want". There is a growing global realization of the need to establish a harmonized African higher education system for facilitating the mobility of trained people with accredited qualifications. Similarly, increased attention is being given to quality and quality assurance in higher education. The rapid growth in the number of students and higher education institutions (HEIs), and the increased focus on employability, have made quality and quality assurance central topics in the global higher education community. This is necessary in order to make education and training count when investing in Africa's population in order to reap demographic dividends.

In order to liberate its full potential and work cooperatively to realize its aspirations, Africa has to:

- (1)** Unleash its potential to become self-reliant in its higher education provision, by for example, making good governance the hallmark of its higher education institutions; and
- (2)** Assuring fair distribution of resources, greater equity and opportunity for all to access higher education by establishing multilateral relationships and programmes, where joint or cooperative ventures will promote quality assurance, mobility, exchange, and pooling of resources and capacities in higher education. Higher education institutions are vitally important vehicles to achieve these aspirations (ASG-QA; 2018: pg5). Quality Assurance in Higher Education has become a major topic of discussion across the African continent due to the important role it has, will, and can play in enhancing the efficiency, effectiveness and productivity of the African Higher Education Institutions. It has therefore become imperative for nations and various stakeholders to be interested and directly involved in the approach to Quality Assurance.

It has become a cliché to talk about the youthful population possessed by the African continent. However, what has not become a cliché, is the need to engage the youth as an indispensable stakeholder to shape the future of the African

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continent. The “Africa We Want” cannot be created when its youth and students are not directly involved in the process of creating that Africa or stand up to do so.

Since its inception in 1972, The All-Africa Students Union’s core mandate includes ensuring active participation of the African student and youth in the development of their countries and the African continent as a whole. The Union, as the mouthpiece of all students on the continent and in the diaspora also takes into consideration the significance of the ordinary African Youth to have ACCESS to AFFORDABLE and QUALITY EDUCATION.

Deming W. Edwards also stressed in one of his most popular quotations that, “Quality is everyone’s Responsibility” Improving Quality Assurance, Harmonization and Standardization of Higher Education across the continent requires the active participation of all stakeholders at institutional, national, regional and continental levels. As such, the All-Africa Students’ Union, together with its partners and various stakeholders has set up the AASU Quality Assurance Ambassadors project that is intended to mobilize students as Quality Assurance Ambassadors from their respective countries.

WHAT ARE THE CHALLENGES TO BEADDRESSED BY THE PROJECT

Harmonized quality higher education systems are imperative for Africa to realize the potential of higher education facilitated by research in achieving its vision of an integrated, prosperous and peaceful continent.

Some of the challenges posed at higher education in Africa to be addressed by this project include, but are not limited to:

1.

Absence or very little harmonization in African higher education in different countries;

2.

Limited student & staff mobility;

3.

Underutilization of resources due to limited intra-Africa sharing and exchange programmes.

OVERALL AIM OF THE PROJECT

The overall objective of the AASU QAA project is to have a solid representation of the African youth and students to support and proffer innovative and creative means to achieve the goal of enhancing the effectiveness, efficiency and acceptability of quality assurance continent-wide. The All-Africa Students Union is committed to fostering unity and harmony amongst the African youth to harness their talents and intellects for the development, advancement and growth of the continent. Effort towards the harmonization of African higher education quality assurance and accreditation is increasing since the diverse national systems didn't have the aspects of recognition of university degrees, thereby constraining academic integration and student mobility across the continent. The African Union (AU)'s vision of building an integrated Africa requires a harmonized education system, which enhances intra-Africa mobility through portable skills that are necessary for integration. The Continental Education Strategy for Africa (CESA 16-25) recognizes that 'Harmonized education and training systems are essential for the realization of intra-Africa mobility and academic integration through regional cooperation as articulated in its Guiding Principles.

The role of quality assurance is, therefore, crucial in supporting African higher education systems and institutions in responding to the challenges related to legal frameworks, governance, funding, qualifications of teaching staff, and research capacity, among other things. To address some of these challenges and ensure quality, there is need for collaboration and sharing of resources between institutions, both locally and internationally; and through student exchange and international cooperation to allow for greater mobility of both staff and students (African Standards and Guidelines – Quality Assurance, 2018: pg6). The AASU QAA project will rely on established and adopted frameworks in Africa to serve as guidelines in the achievement of the intended targets. The guiding framework will be: The Pan African Quality Assurance and Accreditation Framework (PAQAF), which is made up of the following:

- The Continental Quality Assurance Agency
- African Standards and Guidelines for Quality Assurance (ASG-QA)
- Continental Qualifications Framework
- African Quality Rating Mechanism (AQRM)
- Addis Convention, 2014
- African Credit Accumulation and Transfer System (CATS)
- The Minimum Body of Knowledge (MBK)
- Continental Register for QA agencies and quality assured higher education institutions

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

1. The establishment of the African Students Quality Assurance Network
2. Projected positive voice of the African students/youth towards development through Quality Assurance
3. Capacity building in areas of critical Higher Education reforms and Quality Assurance
4. Bridging the standards and qualifications framework gap between and among nations through the harmonization of African Higher Education quality assurance and accreditation so as to enhance staff (skills) and student mobility.
5. Build a cadre of experts in the field of Quality Assurance among African Higher Education students since they are the next generation workforce for the continent.
6. Policy Briefs
7. Bi-annual reports

AASU Higher Education Quality Assurance Ambassadors Project (QAP)/How Do We Intend To Achieve These Goals?

HOW DO WE INTEND TO ACHIEVE THESE GOALS?

The Student QA Ambassadors are expected to undergo a series of online training sessions and onsite workshops to equip them for the tasks ahead in mobilizing students as stakeholders in improving Quality Assurance in Higher Education on the African continent. The AASU Quality Assurance Ambassadors will be expected to carry out specific duties in enhancing the chances of achieving the related objectives through the following:

- Dialogues on Quality Assurance practices & information sharing (conferences, workshops, etc.)
- Dissemination of good practices in Quality Assurance in Higher Education
- Cooperation & trust building
- Mobilizing student ambassadors to serve as agents of change and advancement of Quality Assurance in their respective countries
- Research to aid the harmonization processes

MAIN ACTIVITIES

Ahead of the project these are the following proposed activities:

1. Consultative Forum on Quality Assurance Ambassadors
2. An AASU Declaration on Quality Assurance and the involvement of Country Ambassadors at the student level
3. Call for application for the AASU QAA
4. Screening and selection of applications to choose Ambassadors
5. An online platform for free tuition on Higher Education Quality Assurance
6. Intra and Inter-Country dialogue for workshops and conferences on Higher Education Quality Assurance and Accreditation
7. Liaising of Ambassadors with their respective in-country Quality Assurance and Accreditation Agencies (QAAs) to foster collaborations and harmonization in working together to achieve the shared goals.

AASU Higher Education Quality Assurance Ambassadors Project (QAP)/Responsibilities Of Ambassadors

Responsibilities of the Ambassadors may include but not limited to:

1. Acting as advocates for best practices in Quality Assurance and Higher Educational reforms
2. Mobilizing the youth of their country to contribute effectively on the discourse of Quality Assurance in African Higher Education
3. Act as research coordinators whenever AASU intends to undertake such researches in their country
4. Be responsible for the organization of workshops and conferences in their country under the All-Africa Students Union



ELIGIBILITY TO QUALIFY AS AN AMBASSADOR

To qualify as an AASU QA Ambassador for one's country applicants should meet the following requirements:

1. 
Be between the ages of 19 - 30
2. 
Have a degree or better from any recognized and accredited tertiary institution
3. 
An African (whether by birth, marriage, etc.) and should reside in his or her respective African country as at the time of application
4. 
A training or education on quality assurance will be an added advantage
5. 
Gender balance will also be considered.

KEY TARGET BENEFICIARY POPULATION

The AASU QAA project will be on country basis. Thus, there should be an AASU QA Ambassador from each African country, who is expected to aid and champion the course of Quality Assurance and African Higher Education Harmonisation and Standardisation.

The following benefits may apply to successful applicants:

1. 
Opportunity to attend workshops and conferences on Quality Assurance and Higher Education across the globe
2. 
A wide learning opportunity for ambassadors through the workshops and conferences which will be organised
3. 
Vast networking opportunities. Ambassadors will connect with other Africans as well as with Quality Assurance experts to enhance knowledge sharing



SUSTAINABILITY

The All-Africa Students Union, will be working hand in hand with its key partners to make this an ongoing project that will be to the long-term benefit of the African Continent in the Higher Education sector and also enhance youth engagement in national and continental development. AASU will also liaise with Governments, Ministers of Education and other key stakeholders in the education field in each country to make this initiative a success.

For a start, the project is expected to be piloted in 5 countries across the 5 sub-regions in Africa. Upon a successful pilot, the project will now be scaled continent-wide with the support of all partners.

AASU Higher Education Quality Assurance Ambassadors Project (QAP)/Key Partners



Association of African Universities

The Association of African Universities (AAU) is an international non-profit, non-governmental organization created by African universities to promote cooperation between them on the one hand, and between them and the international academic community on the other. AAU is the Implementing arm of the African Union Commission on Higher Education matters and the Coordinator of The Continental Education Strategy for Africa (CESA-16-25). Created in 1967, the AAU is also the voice of higher education in Africa. It aims to improve the quality of African higher education, and to strengthen its contribution to Africa's development by supporting the core functions of higher education institutions and facilitating critical reflection and consensus building on issues affecting higher education in Africa. To that effect, AAU is the one that is currently responsible for the Harmonization of African Higher Education Quality Assurance and Accreditation (HAQAA) Initiative Project, an AUC brainchild, which is now in its Phase II.



Trust Africa

Trust Africa, originally called the "Special Initiative for Africa", is an independent foundation that works to secure the conditions for democracy and equitable development throughout the continent. TrustAfrica works principally through collaboration and partnership with like-minded institutions and donors. As a catalyst and convener, they are committed to generating and testing new ideas. We believe that Trust Africa as a partner can provide critical technical and financial support to ensure the execution of this project.

KEY PARTNERS

KEY PARTNERS

Ministers of Education

Since the project will be executed at the national and continental levels it becomes important to have these ministries as partners. The ministries can become the very agents who can make critical inputs to suit the country contexts. The Ministries can also be an important partner when it comes to access to relevant logistics.



ABOUT THE LEAD ORGANISATION (AASU)

AASU is the largest student movement in Africa and a very dominant force on the Continent and beyond. The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) organizes all students in Africa from the basic level to Institutions of higher learning; in essence, the Union is the umbrella organization for all students of Africa. Since its inception in 1972, AASU now has presence in 54 Countries in Africa. As the Continent's largest students group, AASU played an important role in the struggle against colonialism and the ending of apartheid. Today, AASU is at the forefront of the fights for equal access to quality education, quality assurance in higher education, harmonization of higher education systems with key emphasis on mobility of students and academics, and comparability of qualifications, democratic governance, defending students' rights, promotion of gender and African culture, sustainable development, entrepreneurship, fostering of academic freedom, freedom of research and autonomy of higher institutions of learning, and the promotion of peace and democratic values, and other noteworthy objectives. In the year 2000, the United Nations (UN) awarded AASU a certificate of merit in recognition of the Union's efforts at advancing students' rights and championing the democratization of education across the African Continent.

Our strategic approach is to address the crucial issues affecting African students and young people, as such, we have identified Seven (7) Strategic Priorities to guide our work at the Secretariat in accordance with the aims and objectives of the Union. AASU's Strategic Priorities are fully aligned to the UN and AU's development priorities as articulated in the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Agenda 2063 respectively. In addition, these priorities complement the global efforts to build a relevant contemporary human capital, capable of fitting into the global citizen ecosystem.

STRATEGIC PRIORITIES OF THE ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION

The Seven (7) Strategic Priorities of the Union are:

GENDER ADVOCACY
ENVIRONMENT & CLIMATE ACTION
DEMOCRACY & GOOD GOVERNANCE
CAPACITY BUILDING
MIGRATION & MOBILITY
EDUCATION & STUDENTS RIGHTS
PAN-AFRICANISM & AFRICAN CULTURE



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